

How Eunoia Endorses Universal Happiness through Accessible Mental Health Education By Eileen Liu

Everyone wants to be happy. It's a fundamental human right written into the nation's Declaration of Independence. Yet it would shock many to learn that mental health holds the key to happiness through shaping the mind's perception of events.

The recent COVID-19 Pandemic has given light on this: rates of depression and anxiety increased 6 times, skyrocketing to 50%. Mental health has been deemed a "public health crisis." Instead, mental health is stigmatized, creating barriers to proper support and resources, and this long-standing issue only becomes more severe as it remains unaddressed. Stress not only impacts the current generation, but creates a cycle of downstream consequences for future generations.

2/3s of people have experience 1+ adverse childhood experiences (ACEs), and 1/8 of people have experiences 4+ ACEs. A buildup of toxic stress from an early age creates physical wear and tear on the body, resulting in health problems and destruction of brain cells. This leads to cognitive problems in self-regulation, academics, relationship skills, and mental illness. When left untreated, this leads to financial difficulties and extremely severe public health issues such as gun shootings, robberies, and other large-scale crimes. Individuals who go on to have families bring this adverse environment to their children as well, leading to intergenerational cycles of trauma, abuse, systemic racism, and the wealth gap. While public health, healthcare, mental health, education, and policy seek to mitigate these collateral societal consequences through programs such as CalFresh, Medicaid, etc, the scale is beyond these organizations and they face barriers with lack of funding and resources. No one wants to come forward, yet removing these obstacles has vast positive effects on the psychology of millions of children.

Eunoia gives hope to breaking this cycle by teaching young children resilience to stressful events through building research-backed cognitive, socio-emotional, and physical toolboxes that universally allow kindergarten children, teachers, and parents to simultaneously learn and practice these exercises throughout their lives. The curriculum was built alongside Davina Chan, who believes that "happiness and well-being are best regarded as skills fundamentally no different than learning to play a musical instrument."



Similar early interventions, such as the one by Blackwell and Dweck giving predominately low-achieving minority students 100-minute interventions on study skills and intelligence, have been shown to reverse longtime trends of decreasing academic scores, demonstrating that the consequences of stress are reversible.

Therefore, the curriculum builds on the growth mindset, which gives hope that small everyday changes through using these tools can drive self-directed neuroplasticity to slowly restructure the brain and create positive perceptions of stress, called Eustress. Eustress leads to downstream benefits through strengthening routine and physical needs, leading to better cognitive functioning in coping, growth, self-regularization, and social-emotional skills in relationships, ultimately creating positive shifts in community, empathy, and nurturing relationships leading to cycles of intergenerational resilience and sustained happiness.

Providing free universal mental health education helps shape young brains and society from inside out, leading to universal happiness and elimination of stigmas. To resist barriers of accessibility, Eunoia is built off a human-centered design that focuses on being free and scalable. Through regional expansion of the program, campaigning, advocating for policy change, and digitization, Eunoia's ultimate goal is to create ground toward happier societies.



EUNOIA

Universal Mental Health Education to kindergartener to build resilience that combats the effects of Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACEs) and cycles of inequality.

Types of ACEs

- 1

Neglect
- 2

Abuse
- 3

Racism
- 4

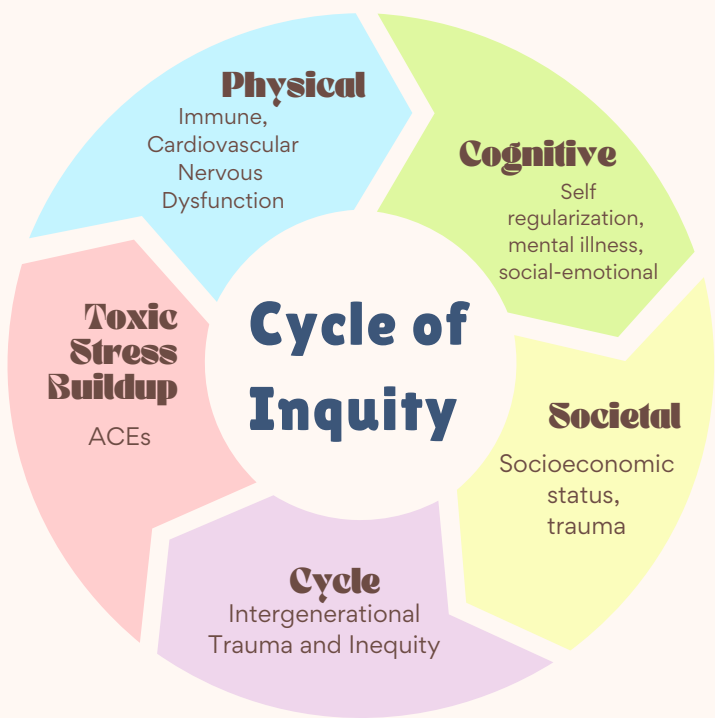
Household Struggles



2/3 adults have 1+ ACEs



1/8 adults have 4+ ACEs



Barriers to help



Perpetually Repairing Societal Collateral Issues



Accessibility to help
Stigmas, fear, cultural barriers



Costly: People Money Time
Burnout, overworked underpaid

Protective Factors

- 1

Education
- 2

Resilience
- 3

Nurturing Caregivers
- 4

Physical Needs & Routine
- 5

Supportive Relationships



Education in Resilience

Free universal mental health education for **kindergarteners, families, and teachers**, that teaches **resilience** through developing **3 toolsets**.



Physical Toolbox

Sleep hygiene, nature, exercise, nutrition, milestones, basic needs, routine

Cognitive Toolbox

Attachment, boundary setting, kindness, empathy, relationship skills, decision making, social/self awareness

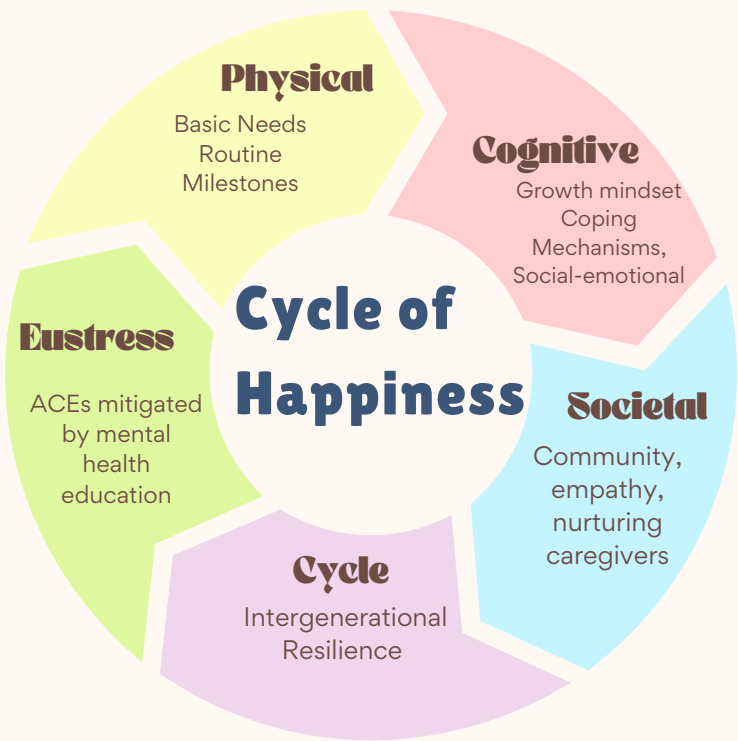
Socio-emotional Toolbox

Attention, cognitive reappraisal, mindfulness, self-regularization, purpose, coping, optimism, self-esteem, technology use, gratitude, asking for help

Small changes in brain patterns during early childhood drive sustained happiness!



"Take a deep breathing while humming"
Exercises only take 5 min a day!



SUMMARY OF PROBLEM



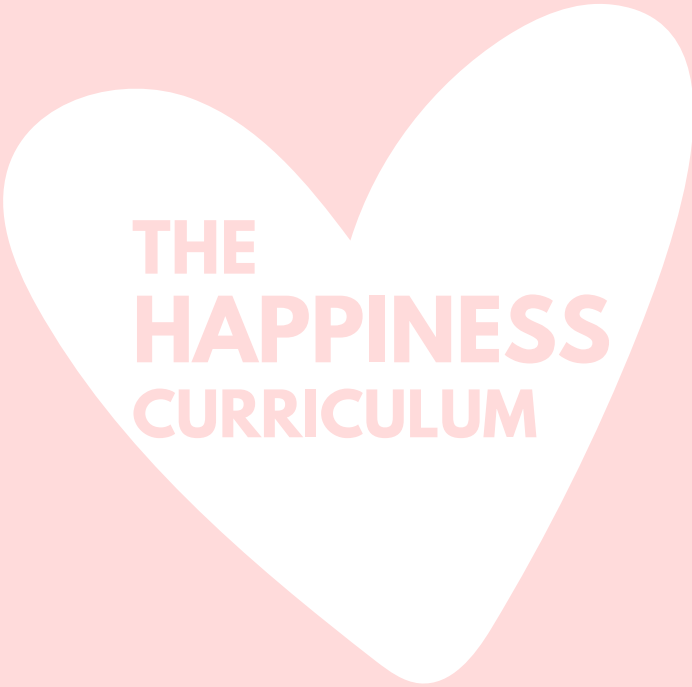
EUNOIA

IS A NON-PROFIT WITH A MISSION IN THE
NAME ITSELF

The word Eunoia was used by Aristotle and translates to “Well mind, beautiful thinking,” or a state of normal mental health in medical settings.

Accordingly, Eunoia seeks to instill beautiful thinking through universal mental health education that promotes resilience, in order to help children reach their full potential, and create peaceful and **happier societies.**

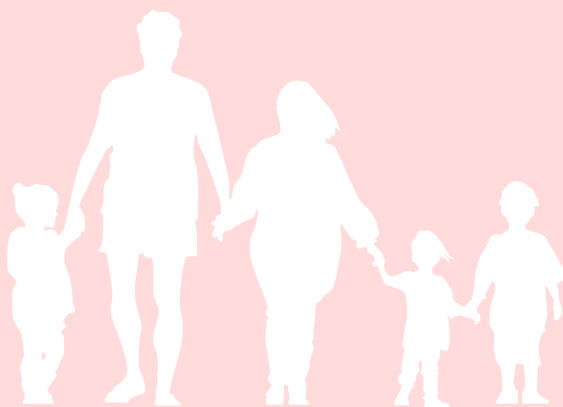
“WELL MIND,
BEAUTIFUL
THINKING”



THE HAPPINESS CURRICULUM

Eunoia's Happiness Curriculum is developed and **curated by Eunoia educators** to promote **resiliency in early-childcare providers, teachers, children, and families** in the same **kindergarten classroom climate** through teaching strategies for resiliency. Eunoia seeks to teach resiliency through developing a **research-based and kid-friendly toolset** in the community which incorporates parental knowledge, and **social-emotional, physical, and cognitive skills** backed by integrative developmental research. The curriculum was formulated with the guidance of **Dr. Davina Chan**, a professor at UC Berkeley that teaches The Neuropsychology of Happiness. The toolboxes and exercises listed have all been shown to neurologically counteract the toxic stress response and improve overall well-being. Distinctly, the curriculum also teaches when and how to ask for help, helping individuals understand where and how to access mental health services, facilitating easier navigation to additional support.

The curriculum takes a holistic approach in building core life skills through fostering strong responsive and nurturing relationships between children, adults, and the community, ultimately affecting physical, mental identity, social emotional, academic, and cognitive development in all. This universal promotion to all provides high-quality lessons which result in a positive shift in mindset in communities, helping **shape culture** and policies within the school, neighborhood, and society, and creating **deep continuous change**



3 TOOL-BOXES

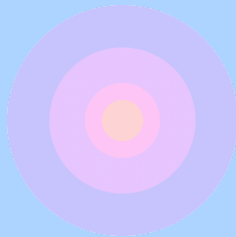
FOR RESILIENCE



Exercises only take 5 min a day!

COGNITIVE TOOLBOX

Change behaviors through self-directed neuroplasticity.



EX. MEDITATION: Sit, close eyes, and still your thoughts

Attention
Mindfulness
Cognitive Appraisal
Self-Regulation
Finding Meaning/Purpose
Coping Mechanisms
Optimism
Self-esteem
Technology regulation
Gratitude
How to Ask for Help

SOCIAL-EMOTIONAL TOOLBOX

Builds healthy relationship skills within a community setting.



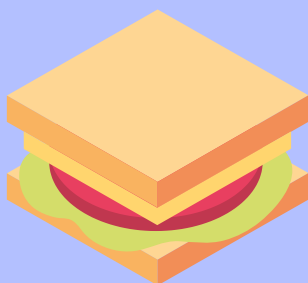
EX. GRATITUDE LETTER: Write a gratitude letter to someone you care about

Attachment
Kindness
Boundary Setting
Empathy
Relationship skills
Responsible Decision Making
Social and Self-Awareness

*Collaborative for academic social and emotional learning (CASEL) – CASEL is a great resource that provides the most up to date research in social-emotional learning.

PHYSICAL TOOLBOX

Learn how to meet Basic Needs



EX. MINDFUL EATING: Chew slowly and feel the texture of the food

Consistency & Routine
Knowledge of milestones
Sleep hygiene
Access to nature
Regular physical activity
Balanced nutrition
Basic Needs Resources

See a more detailed curriculum [here](#)

WHY IT WORKS: THE 5 PILLARS OF RESILIENCE

1) UNIVERSAL EDUCATION

2) SELD-DIRECTED NEUROPLASTICITY

3) QUALITY CAREGIVERS

4) BASIC NEEDS

5) SUPPORTIVE RELATIONSHIPS

SUMMARY OF SOLUTION RATIONALE

